

Tobacco and Health

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TIRC Reports Progress In Smoking-Health Research

Continuing scientific research lends support to the position that too many unknowns exist today concerning lung cancer to warrant conclusions placing a major causative role on cigarette smoking, according to the 1957 Report of the Scientific Director of the Tobacco Industry Research Committee.

In the report, just published, Dr. Clarence Cook Little discusses some of the unknowns, questions, and problems under study through grants to independent scientists. Dr. Little is also chairman of the Scientific Advisory Board, which recommends all grants to be made by the Tobacco Industry Research Committee.

"Broad and specific accusations and claims of harmful effects from tobacco have been made," he said, "and the incorrectness or correctness of such statements must be proved, no matter how long or how difficult the effort may be."

Seek New Facts

"The program of the Scientific Advisory Board is one of basic and unbiased research," he said. "It is not planned with a preconceived purpose of proving tobacco innocent or guilty in its effects on human health. Its purpose is solely to obtain new information and to advance human knowledge in every possible phase of the tobacco and health relationship."

Dr. Little said the nine scientists on the Board "take the general position that definitive conclusions on predictions of individual risks are unwarranted by the present state of knowledge in the complex field of lung cancer causation."

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REPORT AVAILABLE

Copies of the 1957 Report of the Scientific Director of the Tobacco Industry Research Committee are available upon request to: Executive Secretary, Tobacco Industry Research Committee, Room 3405, 150 East 42nd Street, New York 17, N. Y.

'Tar' Misnomer For Condensed Smoke

The term "tobacco tar," often seen in articles about smoking, actually is a misnomer.

Recognition of this fact is necessary to an understanding of some of the difficulties involved in analyzing and assaying tobacco smoke.

A discussion of this problem is contained in the 1957 Annual Report of the Scientific Director of the Tobacco Industry Research Committee.

Many factors affect the composition of the smoke itself. In laboratory work, tobacco smoke when trapped and condensed becomes a dark-colored, viscous liquid. This apparently has led to the use of the term "tobacco tar." However, this liquid is not a substance which is the same from one experiment to the next.

Smoke Varies

As a result, different investigators may be using different condensates whose contents are far from standardized or known. Such experiments may be with material that is not comparable to the smoke that people get when they smoke.

Tobacco smoke produced during the normal burning of a cigarette has two phases. One, virtually invisible, is a complex mixture of gases and vapors. The other is a

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New Statistics Contradict Anti-Cigarette Theory

Cigarette smoking is compatible with normal health, and even heavier-than-average cigarette smoking is compatible with better-than-average mortality rates, according to a scientific report presented before the Southern Medical Association.

This finding is based on a study of cigarette factory employees covering 115,000 person-years of mortality risk over a 10½-year span. The workers:

- (1) Smoke far more cigarettes than the general U.S. population — almost double the average rate;
- (2) Definitely live longer than average;
- (3) Show average, or lower-than-average, death rates for cancer or lung cancer, and for cardiovascular and coronary disease.

The report was presented by Dr. H. B. Haag, professor of pharmacology, Medical College of Virginia, and H. R. Hanmer, research director of The American Tobacco Company, whose employees were studied.

"The existence of such a population makes it evident that cigarette smoking per se is not necessarily or invariably associated with a higher risk of lung cancer or cardiovascular disease or with diminished longevity," Haag and Hanmer concluded.

One proponent of the anti-cigarette theory, E. Cuyler Hammond, director of the American Cancer Society's statistical section, criticized the Haag-Hanmer results on two counts: first, that the employees involved enjoy good medical care; and second, that employee populations generally show better-than-average mortality rates.

However, Dr. B. Z. Rigdon, professor of pathology at the University of Texas Medical Branch, in a discussion of the paper, concluded that "Scientists who support the statistical association between cigarette smoking and (1) higher death rates

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